

UPSC Prelims Pointers on the List of Important Acts in India



The list below is categorized for easy navigation and study, covering all major domains assessed in the UPSC examination.

1. Historical & Constitutional Acts (Pre-Independence)

These acts were pivotal in shaping the administrative and constitutional development of India.

Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Regulating Act	1773	First step to control the East India Company; created the post of Governor-General of Bengal.
Pitt's India Act	1784	Established the Board of Control to oversee the Company's political affairs (Dual System).
Charter Act	1813	Ended the Company's monopoly over trade in India (except for tea and trade with China).
Charter Act	1833	Final step towards centralization; made the Governor-General of Bengal the Governor-General of India .
Government of India Act	1858	Transferred power directly to the British Crown; abolished the Court of Directors and Board of Control.
Indian Councils Act	1861	Introduced Indian representation in the non-official capacity of the Governor-General's Council.
Indian Councils Act	1909	Introduced communal representation for Muslims (Morley-Minto Reforms).
Government of India Act	1919	Introduced Dyarchy (dual rule) in the provinces (Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms).
Government of India Act	1935	Provided the basis for the present Constitution; introduced provincial autonomy and an All-India Federation.
Indian Independence Act	1947	Ended British rule and led to the creation of the two independent dominions of India and Pakistan.

2. Polity & Governance

These acts define the functions of the government, elections, and transparency mechanisms.



Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Representation of the People Act (RPA)	1951	Governs the conduct of elections and qualifications/disqualifications of members of Parliament/State Legislatures.
Right to Information (RTI) Act	2005	Empowers citizens to demand information from public authorities, promoting transparency.
Official Secrets Act	1923	Deals with espionage and disclosure of sensitive government information (still in force).
Prevention of Corruption Act	1988	Consolidates laws relating to the prevention of corruption.
Tribunals Reforms Act	2021	Provided for the dissolution of certain existing tribunals and the transfer of their functions to High Courts/Commercial Courts.
Information Technology Act	2000	Deals with cyber crimes and provides legal recognition for electronic documents and digital signatures.

3. Social Justice, Welfare & Rights

These laws guarantee rights, ensure welfare, and protect vulnerable sections of society.

Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education (RTE) Act	2009	Guarantees free and compulsory education for all children between 6 and 14 years (Article 21A).
National Food Security Act (NFSA)	2013	Legal entitlement to subsidized food grains (rice, wheat, coarse grains) to approximately two-thirds of the population.
Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act	2016	Replaced the 1995 Act; increased the number of disabilities recognized to 21 and ensured comprehensive rights.
Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act	2005	Provides for civil remedies and protection orders for women subjected to domestic violence.



Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act	2013	Requires employers to constitute an Internal Complaints Committee (ICC) to deal with harassment complaints.
Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act	1989	Prevents atrocities and heinous crimes against members of SCs and STs.

4. Economy & Business

These acts regulate the financial markets, corporate environment, and trade.

Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC)	2016	Framework for a time-bound process for resolving insolvency of companies and individuals.
Goods and Services Tax (GST) Act	2017	Unified indirect tax structure for the country, replacing multiple central and state taxes.
Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA)	1999	Replaced FERA; regulates foreign exchange transactions and promotes orderly development of the forex market.
Competition Act	2002	Prohibits anti-competitive practices and abuse of dominant market position.
Reserve Bank of India Act (RBI Act)	1934	Established the RBI and defines its powers, functions, and responsibilities.
Negotiable Instruments Act	1881	Governs instruments like cheques, promissory notes, and bills of exchange.

5. Environment, Disaster & Public Safety

These laws are vital for protecting natural resources, managing crises, and maintaining public health.



Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Wildlife Protection Act	1972	Provides for the protection of wild animals, birds, and plants; framework for National Parks and Sanctuaries.
Environment (Protection) Act (EPA)	1986	Umbrella legislation for the protection and improvement of the human environment.
Biological Diversity Act	2002	Aims to conserve biological diversity and regulate access to genetic resources.
Disaster Management Act	2005	Provides for the establishment of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) for effective management of disasters.
Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act	1981	Provides for the control and abatement of air pollution.
Forest Conservation Act	1980	Restricts the de-reservation of forests or use of forest land for non-forest purposes.
Epidemic Diseases Act	1897	Allows states to take special measures and prescribe regulations during an outbreak of a dangerous epidemic disease.

6. Criminal & Security Acts

Act Name	Year	Core Significance
Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act (NDPS Act)	1985	Prohibits the production, possession, sale, and consumption of narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances.
Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA)	1967	Deals with terrorism and unlawful activities; grants special powers to law enforcement agencies.
Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act	2012	Provides a specialized legal framework for the protection of children from sexual abuse.